WEEK 06 / GAMING'S IMPACT ON PEOPLE AND SOCIETY

Games, Society, Religion, War, and Ethics

Exploring the impact of video games on civic engagement and the portrayal of war and violence.

This week, we explore how video games influence civic engagement and discuss the representation of war and violence in gaming. We will analyze the social and political implications of these themes and their effects on players and communities. And we'll also discuss the ethical considerations of game design and content, including the responsibilities of developers and the impact of gaming on societal norms. Finally, we'll explore how religion and spirituality are represented in games, examining the ways in which games can reflect, challenge, or reinforce religious beliefs and practices.

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43 RESOURCES / 1 TOPIC

TOPIC 01

Civic Engagement, War, and Violence

REQUIRED

Civics and Government Education

TED TALK | ~8 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=oOtCBCnDG8g

In the talk, Madelyn Fried, a college freshman at the time of this recording, discusses the importance of civics education, noting a significant decline in its instruction across U.S. schools. She highlights that many students lack a fundamental understanding of government, even struggling with basic concepts like 'What is Congress?'. To address this educational gap, Fried created 'Civic's Clicker,' a video game designed to make learning about U.S. government engaging and accessible for young people, even incorporating questions from the official U.S. citizenship practice test. Beyond the game, she emphasizes that active civic participation, including consistent voting in local elections, is crucial for a healthy democracy and encourages individuals to educate themselves about the system, regardless of their background, to ensure all voices are heard. Also see the Civics Clicker (https://mfried.itch.io/civics-clicker) game online.

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.

REQUIRED

Gaming can make a better world

TED TALK | ~20 MIN

https://www.ted.com/talks/jane_mcgonigal_gaming_can_make_a_better_world

Jane McGonigal, a game designer, argues that the vast amount of time people spend playing online games can be leveraged to solve real-world problems. She asserts that gamers develop 'superpowers' like urgent optimism, strong social connections, blissful productivity, and a desire for epic meaning through their gameplay experiences. McGonigal believes that if we can transfer these positive attributes and the immersive, rewarding nature of games to real-life challenges, humanity can overcome significant global obstacles. She illustrates this concept with examples of games she's designed that encourage players to collaboratively tackle fictional crises and develop innovative solutions, aiming to inspire a shift from saving virtual worlds to saving the actual one. Among other things, she argues that we need to spend 21 billion hours a week playing video games instead of the 3 billion that we currently spend. Learn more about World Without Oil (https://worldwithoutoil.org/metahome.htm), SuperStruct (https://legacy.iftf.org/our-work/people-technology/games/superstruct/), and Evoke (https://www.worldbank.org/en/topic/edutech/brief/evoke-an-online-alternate-reality-game-supporting-social-innovation-among-young-people-around-the-world).

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REQUIRED

Why video games aren't a waste of time

TED TALK | ~12 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=6hceniC3FZw

This video, a TEDx Talk by Deborah Mensah-Bonsu, argues that video games are not a waste of time but rather a powerful medium with significant positive potential. Mensah-Bonsu highlights four key 'superpowers' of games: agency, empathy, imagination, and community, explaining how these elements foster valuable skills and connections. She emphasizes that games can be utilized for social impact, citing examples of initiatives that leveraged gaming communities for real-world environmental action and education. Ultimately, the talk asserts that the gaming industry, with its massive global reach and engaged player base, holds unrivaled power to inspire positive change and address pressing global issues.

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.

REQUIRED

Research Roundup: Video Games and Civic Engagement

BLOG POST | ~7 MIN

https://www.filamentgames.com/blog/research-roundup-video-games-and-civic-engagement/

This explores the intersection of video games and civic engagement, presenting various research findings on how games can enhance civic education and political participation. Several studies highlight that game-based learning can effectively improve knowledge, skills, and attitudes related to civics, negotiation, and conflict resolution across different age groups, including university students and older adults. The text also indicates that political video games can foster heightened political participation and civic engagement, leading to increased awareness and real-world discussions. Furthermore, the incorporation of augmented reality in civic education is shown to create more positive academic emotions and improved learning environments. Overall, the sources collectively demonstrate that digital games serve as a valuable tool for promoting social connectedness and civic participation, making civic engagement more accessible and educational.

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine,

education, and social engagement.

REQUIRED

In this case, politics is a (video) game

ARTICLE/AUDIO | ~6 MIN

https://www.npr.org/2021/11/04/1051381706/in-this-case-politics-is-a-video-game

NPR discusses 'Political Arena,' a new strategy game designed by journalist Eliot Nelson that offers players an immersive, realistic simulation of national politics. The game allows users to create and guide their own politician through legislative processes, campaigns, media navigation, and scandals, aiming to represent the complexities and less glamorous aspects of the political world. Inspired by educational games like Oregon Trail and sports simulations, 'Political Arena' seeks to entertain while subtly educating players about democracy, portraying both its functional and ethically ambiguous facets. The game emphasizes authentic reactions to player choices, including a politician's gender and race, to enhance realism and player engagement.

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REQUIRED

Military Historian breaks down Call of Duty: Modern Warfare (2019)

ARTICLE | ~9 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ZjgKxrH0JU8

This video from the UK's Imperial War Museums' YouTube channel features a military historian analyzing the video game Call of Duty: Modern Warfare (2019) to assess its realism regarding modern warfare. The discussion highlights the game's accurate depiction of weaponry, character models, and sound effects, praising its attention to detail in areas like night vision technology. However, it also points out where the game takes creative liberties with real-world events, such as adapting the 'Highway of Death' scenario, while still reflecting complex themes like the murky nature of modern conflict and the rise of special forces operations. The analysis also covers the game's portrayal of Russia as an antagonist, drawing connections to Cold War influences and contemporary Russian military tactics, and examines the inclusion of civilian perspectives through characters inspired by groups like the Kurdish Peshmerga, ultimately concluding that the game, despite its fictional elements, offers significant insights into contemporary warfare. If you find this interesting, there is a similar video from the same channel in the additional resources.

LO 4: Students will be able to discuss ethical concerns surrounding gaming, including issues related to violence, addiction, monetization practices, labor concerns, and virtual identities.

REQUIRED

Video Games Debate: Should Kids and Teens Be Allowed to Play Violent Video Games?

ARGUMENT SUMMARY | ~29 MIN

https://www.britannica.com/procon/video-games-debate

This page explores the ongoing debate surrounding violent video games and their impact on youth. It traces the history of public concern from early arcade games to modern titles, highlighting instances where games were blamed for real-world violence, particularly in the wake of mass shootings. The text also details attempts at regulation, including the establishment of the ESRB rating system and unsuccessful legislative efforts to ban sales to minors due to First Amendment protections. Finally, it presents a pro/con analysis of allowing children and teens to play these games, discussing arguments related to play and imagination, emotional regulation, community building, and societal scapegoating versus increased aggression in predisposed individuals, addiction, reduced outdoor activity, and the inherent exposure to violence. Includes an extensive list of sources for more information.

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REQUIRED

Call of Duty: Pentagon Ops

ARTICLE | ~25 MIN

https://www.thenation.com/article/society/call-of-duty-pentagon-ops-2/

Examines the deep and intertwined relationship between the U.S. military and the video gaming industry, particularly focusing on the Call of Duty franchise. It explains how the Pentagon's early investments in simulation technology for military training directly influenced the development of modern video games, leading to a synergistic 'military-entertainment complex.' The article highlights how games like Call of Duty not only reflect but also shape perceptions of warfare, sometimes even serving as recruitment tools for the armed forces. Ultimately, it suggests that this convergence blurs the lines between simulated combat and real-world military operations, impacting both the nature of entertainment and the broader militarization of society. Among other things, it describes SIMNET, developed in the 1980s by the Pentagon, as effectively the first “massively multiplayer online role-playing game” (MMORPG). Note that it incorrectly describes Doom II’s introduction as shareware enabling anyone to modify its source code; Doom II was shareware, but shareware doesn’t mean the source can be modified - that is open source, and Doom II was not open source until 1997; Marine Doom was a mod for Doom - as we discussed, id software encouraged modding of some of their games, including Doom II, and provided documentation and tools to make modding easier, including the WAD file format (which stands for Where’s All the Data?) that was used to store packages of game files that could be replaced by providing a modified WAD file.

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REQUIRED

Stalker 2 is a survival game made by people surviving a war. Should you play it?

AUDIO | ~9 MIN

https://www.cbc.ca/listen/live-radio/1-14-day-6/clip/16110908-stalker-2-survival-game-made-people-surviving-war

Discusses the sequel to the S.T.A.L.K.E.R. video game, which was released last November. The game is about war and was produced in Ukraine as it was in the middle of a war. Talks about both the game and its history.

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REQUIRED

I Interviewed The REAL Arthur Morgan - Roger Clark

YOUTUBE | ~75 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=XSyDS6gBt00

This is an interview with Roger Clark, the man who played Arthur Morgan in Red Dead Redemption 2, and Dr. Tore C. Olsson, who wrote Red Dead's History, a deep dive into the real-world history behind RDR2 and The Wild West. Includes discussion of the historical context and representation. BTW, Roger voiced the audiobook (in character as Arthur). I loved the audiobook and the interview.

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LO 7: Students will be able to express informed perspectives on gaming in written reflections and class discussions, connecting course content to broader social and cultural contexts.

REQUIRED

I Dream of Indie Games Podcast: What Religious Themes in Games Make Us Feel-And Why It Matters (listen to segment from 32:00 to 44:27)

YOUTUBE | ~13 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=vlwiU-IdMG0&t=1920s

Listen to just this one segment from the larger video, 32:00 to 44:27. Discusses examples of religious depictions and elements incorporated into video games along with the panelists' opinions of the ethics of such examples.

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REQUIRED

EFMS - Religion in Video Games

YOUTUBE | ~14 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=snYrwGow9jE

This commentary explores the complex intersection of faith and interactive entertainment, examining how video games often shy away from religious themes despite their profound cultural significance. The text traces the evolution of the industry from 'god games' like Populous to modern narratives in BioShock and Skyrim that use fiction to address secularism, persecution, and political control. By highlighting the lack of authentic representation for religions like Islam, the source argues that developers frequently rely on stereotypes or avoid the subject entirely to escape controversy. Ultimately, the piece advocates for intelligent and subtle inclusion of religious identity, suggesting that embracing these sensitive topics can provide deeper emotional resonance and a more inclusive experience for players.

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LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the

contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

REQUIRED

The Word Has Become Game: Researching Religion in Digital Games

ARTICLE | ~25 MIN

https://research.tilburguniversity.edu/en/publications/the-word-has-become-game-researching-religion-in-digital-games/

In this academic article, Frank Bosman outlines a comprehensive framework for analyzing the intersection of theology and digital media. He first establishes a nuanced definition of video games as digital, playable, and narrative texts, bridging the traditional gap between game mechanics and storytelling. To organize how faith appears in these spaces, Bosman identifies five distinct levels of religious engagement, ranging from explicit material content and external references to deep existential reflection and player-led rituals. Finally, he advocates for a four-step research methodology that requires scholars to combine immersive personal gameplay with a thorough investigation of developer intent and community reception.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Restoring Youth Civic Engagement

TED TALK | ~10 MIN

https://www.ted.com/talks/noah_tesfaye_restoring_youth_civic_engagement

Noah Tesfaye advocates for improved civics education in the United States, highlighting its crucial role in boosting youth voter turnout and fostering an informed electorate. They argue that the decline in youth civic engagement is linked to a lack of comprehensive civics instruction from an early age, contrasting current statistics with past engagement levels and immigrant pass rates on citizenship tests. The speaker challenges the notion of over-politicizing classrooms, asserting that open discussions are vital for developing critical thinking and understanding governmental functions. Ultimately, the address emphasizes that robust civics education is essential for a healthy democracy, encouraging young people to actively participate in the political process through voting and community engagement.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

World Reborn

WEBSITE

https://www.worldreborn.com/

World Reborn is an interactive story game platform where players practice becoming a hero (dealing with bullying, prejudice, etc.) within the mobile game and then unlock missions to be a hero in real life.

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Gamers.Vote

WEBSITE

https://gamers.vote/

Gamers.Vote is a platform encouraging gamers to engage in voting and civic participation.

LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Are Video Games Breeding an Assassination Generation?

ARTICLE | ~6 MIN

https://maine.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01MAINE_INST/1oa9cn5/cdi_proquest_miscellaneous_1847442758

This article from The Daily Beast, argues that violent video games are a primary cause of aggression and real-world violence, particularly in children. Written by Lt. Col. Dave Grossman, a retired Army officer and author, the piece highlights numerous mass shootings and violent incidents that the author believes are linked to violent media exposure. Grossman advocates for both cultural shifts within families and legislative action to restrict children's access to such games, referencing studies from the American Academy of Pediatrics and the American Psychological Association to support his claims. The article suggests that regulating access to violent video games is crucial for preventing future tragedies and fostering a less violent society.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Assassination Generation: Video Games, Aggression, and the Psychology of Killing

BOOK

https://www.amazon.com/Assassination-Generation-Aggression-Psychology-Killing/dp/0316265934/ref=tmm_hrd_swatch_0?_encoding=UTF8&qid=&sr=

Book description: “Drawing on crime statistics, cutting-edge social research, and scientific studies of the teenage brain, Col. Grossman shows how video games that depict antisocial, misanthropic, casually savage behavior can warp the mind - with potentially deadly results. His book will become the focus of a new national conversation about video games and the epidemic of mass murders that they have unleashed.”

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EXPLORE FURTHER

9-Year-Old Kills Friend For Bragging About Beating Him at a Video Game

YOUTUBE | ~7 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=8l1arhnfKok

The tragic tale of a 9-year-old boy who killed his friend for bragging about beating him at a video game in 1989. Although not directly related to depictions of violence in video games, this story highlights the potential for violence and aggression in gaming culture.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Ain’t No Place for a Hero: Borderlands (Pop Classics Book 8)

BOOK

https://www.amazon.com/Aint-No-Place-Hero-Borderlands-ebook/dp/B06ZZZ4WP9/

Book description: “A deep dive into the groundbreaking and bestselling video game series”

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Red Dead's History: A Video Game, an Obsession, and America's Violent Past

BOOK

https://www.amazon.com/Red-Deads-History-Obsession-Americas/dp/1250287707/

The book mentioned earlier. The book is fascinating and Roger Clark’s reading makes it extra enjoyable.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

On School Shootings

YOUTUBE | ~30 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=phTTGIEUX7w

Addresses the complex issue of school shootings by challenging the sole focus on mental illness as an excuse for evil actions, advocating instead for individual responsibility. The speaker also questions the effectiveness of current gun control strategies, emphasizing the need for a practical plan to protect children rather than relying on defensive architectural changes or bulletproof accessories. Furthermore, the video explores the societal impact of online "drift," where emotionally engaging content leads to extreme echo chambers and radicalization. Finally, the speaker discusses the science of trauma, advising against immediate forced processing and suggesting activities like playing video games as a beneficial dissociative coping mechanism.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Trauma, War, & Violence | Mental Health In Tough Times

YOUTUBE | ~97 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=2P9b45rH968

Presents an insightful discussion on trauma, war, and coping mechanisms, prompted by current global conflicts. It examines post-war psychological adjustment by drawing on peer-reviewed research, including

qualitative studies of Holocaust survivors and analyses of Bosnian adolescents and Yugoslavian civilians during wartime. The speaker emphasizes that safety and community are paramount for healing, asserting that forgiveness is not always necessary for recovery and that seeking justice can be therapeutic. Furthermore, the discussion distinguishes between engaging (reactive and adaptive) and disengaging coping strategies, explaining how they differentially impact stress responses and highlighting the complexity and individualized nature of trauma recovery.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Violent Video Game Effects on Aggression, Empathy, and Prosocial Behavior in Eastern and Western Countries: A Meta-Analytic Review

ARTICLE | ~109 MIN

https://maine.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01MAINE_INST/11g3o2i/cdi_proquest_miscellaneous_746081983

Presents a meta-analytic review examining the impact of violent video games on various psychological and behavioral outcomes. The research specifically investigates effects on aggression (behavior, cognition, and affect), physiological arousal, empathy/desensitization, and prosocial behavior. A key feature of this meta-analysis is its cross-cultural comparison between Eastern (primarily Japanese) and Western countries, alongside the inclusion of longitudinal studies, providing a comprehensive and robust assessment of the long-term and short-term effects of violent video game exposure. The findings suggest that exposure to violent video games is a causal risk factor for increased aggression and decreased prosocial behavior and empathy across different research designs and cultures.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

War Game: The Making of S.T.A.L.K.E.R. 2 Documentary

YOUTUBE | ~90 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=28CITqxwNz0

A story about the game development and about the people behind S.T.A.L.K.E.R. 2: Heart of Chornobyl. From the company: “It’s about the challenges we faced in continuing the development. We are grateful to the Microsoft team for helping to create this film and sharing our story with the world. Our deepest thanks go to everyone defending and supporting Ukraine. Without you, S.T.A.L.K.E.R. 2: Heart of Chornobyl would not have been possible.”

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Video Games and Youth Violence: A Prospective Analysis in Adolescents

ARTICLE | ~45 MIN

https://maine.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01MAINE_INST/11g3o2i/cdi_proquest_miscellaneous_856771884

A study investigating the link between violent video game exposure and youth aggression found no significant long-term causal relationship. Instead, depressive symptoms emerged as a strong predictor of aggressive and violent behavior in adolescents, particularly when combined with antisocial traits. While acknowledging limitations such as a non-random, Hispanic-majority sample, the research suggests that fears regarding video games as a primary cause of youth violence may be unfounded, advocating for more conservative interpretations of such research findings. The authors emphasize the need for further research considering additional influential factors.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Video Games Do Affect Social Outcomes: A Meta-Analytic Review of the Effects of Violent and Prosocial Video Game Play

ARTICLE | ~52 MIN

https://maine.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/discovery/openurl?institution=01MAINE_INST&vid=01MAINE_INST:UMA&volume=40&date=2014&issn=01461672&issue=5&author=Greitemeyer&genre=article&spage=578&title=Video%20Games%20Do%20Affect%20Social%20Outcomes:%20A%20Meta-Analytic%20Review%20of%20the%20Effects%20of%20Violent%20and%20Prosocial%20Video%20Game%20Play&atitle=Video%20Games%20Do%20Affect%20Social%20Outcomes:%20A%20Meta-Analytic%20Review%20of%20the%20Effects%20of%20Violent%20and%20Prosocial%20Video%20Game%20Play&sid=ProQ:assia

Abstract: "Whether video game play affects social behavior is a topic of debate. Many argue that aggression and helping are affected by video game play, whereas this stance is disputed by others. The present research provides a meta-analytical test of the idea that depending on their content, video games do affect social outcomes. Data from 98 independent studies with 36,965 participants revealed that for both violent video games and prosocial video games, there was a significant association with social outcomes. Whereas violent video games increase aggression and aggression-related variables and decrease prosocial outcomes, prosocial video games have the opposite effects. These effects were reliable across experimental, correlational, and longitudinal studies, indicating that video game exposure causally affects social outcomes and that there are both short- and long-term effects."

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EXPLORE FURTHER

War and Video Games

RESEARCH PROJECT | ~48 MIN

https://digitalcommons.uri.edu/srhonorsprog/123/

Explores the representation of war within video games. Nicholas A. Perry argues that commercial war video games often prioritize entertainment over realistic portrayals of combat and its consequences, differentiating them from military training simulators. The text scrutinizes popular titles like Company of Heroes, Brothers in Arms, and Call of Duty series, analyzing their violence, historical accuracy, and technical details. Ultimately, Perry suggests that despite advancements, no game truly captures the visceral reality of war, advocating for more honest depictions to foster a greater understanding of its true costs.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Military Historian breaks down Sniper Elite 5

YOUTUBE | ~13 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=GIRzeJ_6wk8&ab_channel=ImperialWarMuseums

This second video from the UK's Imperial War Museums' YouTube channel provides an analysis of the video game Sniper Elite 5, specifically examining its historical accuracy through the lens of protagonist Karl Fairburne. The video compares Fairburne's weaponry, missions, and tactics to those of real-life World War II snipers and Special Operations Executive (SOE) agents. While acknowledging that games prioritize entertainment over strict historical adherence, the curator highlights both accurate depictions and significant departures from reality, such as the game's depiction of the "kill cam" and the lack of social consequences for in-game actions. Ultimately, the source concludes that Fairburne is best understood as a classic video game "super soldier" rather than a historically accurate portrayal, reflecting a broader trend in entertainment of framing World War II as a setting for individual heroism.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Codex: History of Video Games #266: The Best Non-Violent Video Games with James Batchelor

PODCAST | ~70 MIN

https://codexhistoryofvideogames.libsyn.com/episode-266-the-best-non-violent-video-games-with-james-batchelor

I love the Codex: History of Video Games podcast and you'll probably see me including it a lot in additional materials. This episode features James Batchelor, author of the book The Best Non-Violent Video Games. They go through some of the games in the book and discuss why non-violent video games are an important part of the industry.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

The Best Non-Violent Video Games

BOOK

https://www.casemateipm.com/9781399084925/the-best-non-violent-video-games/

I've also included a link to the book, which is a comprehensive guide to over 300 non-violent video games, from AAA studios to beloved indies.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

I've been ensnared into the wild life of a drug dealer in Schedule 1

ARTICLE

https://www.polygon.com/gaming/553156/schedule-1-impressions-weed-drug-game

This Polygon article reviews Schedule 1, a drug-dealing simulator game currently popular on Steam, created by a solo developer. The game tasks players with rebuilding a criminal enterprise by cultivating drugs, managing customers, and dealing with rivals and law enforcement, all through satisfying minigames that are not meant to be realistic. While the game features crass humor and simplified graphics, the reviewer finds the core gameplay loop engaging despite the police being easily evaded and some early access incompleteness. The article suggests that future updates will likely enhance the experience, making it a game the reviewer expects to revisit.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Phantasmagoria (PC) - Retro Gaming Review

YOUTUBE | ~13 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=YDj-MdyDdwU&ab_channel=CannotbeTamed

This is a YouTube video review of the 1995 PC game Phantasmagoria. The reviewer, Pam, offers a critical analysis of this horror point-and-click adventure game developed by Sierra and designed by Roberta Williams. While acknowledging the technical achievements of its full-motion video (FMV) elements and the game's historical significance in terms of sales despite controversy, Pam ultimately concludes that Phantasmagoria is a poorly designed and unengaging game due to its slow pacing, lack of player interaction, uneven tone, and unlikable protagonist. Please note that there are graphic gameplay clips.

LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.
LO 4: Students will be able to discuss ethical concerns surrounding gaming, including issues related to violence, addiction, monetization practices, labor concerns, and virtual identities.

EXPLORE FURTHER

A Conversation with Roberta Williams (Phantasmagoria Reunion)

YOUTUBE | ~116 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-z8Eg0IjOac&ab_channel=ConversationswithCurtis

This video is an interview with Roberta Williams, a legendary figure in the video game industry that we've talked about before. Hosted by Paul Stetler, who played Curtis Craig in Sierra Online's Phantasmagoria 2, the conversation primarily centers on Williams's extensive career, including her work on King's Quest and the Phantasmagoria series. She discusses the creative and technical challenges of early video game development, her recent return to game design with Colossal Cave, and her insights into the evolution of the industry. The interview also features a reunion between Williams and Victoria Hemingsen, who starred as Adrian Delaney in the original Phantasmagoria, offering behind-the-scenes anecdotes and reflections on their iconic roles.

LO 1: Students will be able to explain the historical development of video games, from early arcade games to contemporary digital gaming platforms.
LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.
LO 4: Students will be able to discuss ethical concerns surrounding gaming, including issues related to violence, addiction,

monetization practices, labor concerns, and virtual identities.

EXPLORE FURTHER

This War of Mine

GAME

https://www.thiswarofmine.com/

A game that addresses civic and ethical issues.

LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Papers, Please

GAME

https://papersplea.se/

A game that addresses civic and ethical issues.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Papers, Please Short Film

YOUTUBE | ~11 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=YFHHGETsxkE

Short film about Papers, Please, via YouTube.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Papers, Please Short Film

STEAM | ~11 MIN

https://store.steampowered.com/app/804320/Papers_Please__The_Short_Film/

Short film about Papers, Please, via Steam.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Religious Imagery in Video Games

ARTICLE | ~5 MIN

https://themeliorist.ca/2022/11/30/religious-imagery-in-video-games/

This article explores how modern video games utilize religious imagery and mythology to create immersive, awe-inspiring narratives that resonate with players' real-world cultural understanding. By examining specific examples-such as the creation lore of Pokémon, the angelic aesthetics in Super Smash Bros., and the Eastern deities found in Final Fantasy-the author demonstrates that these digital worlds often function as modern mirrors of ancient faith. Rather than mocking spirituality, these games lean into the sense of wonder inherent in theological concepts to deepen their own fictional histories and emotional impact. Ultimately, the text highlights how borrowing from diverse religious traditions enriches the gaming experience, transforming entertainment into a sophisticated platform for exploring the extraordinary and the divine.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Diablo 4’s strange, dismissive relationship with paganism

ARTICLE | ~6 MIN

https://medium.com/@tilfolkvang/diablo-4s-strange-dismissive-relationship-with-paganism-43c7e78a8e7a

The author explores how the Diablo IV universe reinforces a dualistic Christian cosmology, ultimately framing alternative, pagan-inspired spiritualities as mere superstition. While the game world vividly brings the iconography of Heaven and Hell to life, it relegates the nature-based practices of the Scosglen druids to the status of ineffective folk beliefs that lack the mechanical reality of the central angelic-demonic conflict. By contrasting this with the animistic world-building of The Witcher, the text argues that Diablo’s narrative structure forces a secular humanist morality into a rigid, Judeo-Christian framework. The piece concludes that by treating decentralized, Earth-focused faiths as legitimate forces rather than background flavor, developers could achieve a more diverse and compelling mythological landscape.

EXPLORE FURTHER

The Religious Symbolism of Halo ft. @Wendigoon

YOUTUBE | ~23 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=IvvzhxO_P5A

This video analysis explores how the Halo franchise is deeply anchored in religious scripture and symbolism, featuring insights from biblical enthusiast Wendigoon to bridge the gap between game lore and theology. The narrative structure pairs specific in-game terminology-such as the Halo rings, the Covenant, and the Flood-with their scriptural counterparts, illustrating how these elements serve as a galactic retelling of concepts like the Ark and the Apocalypse. Central to this discussion is the character of Master Chief, whose designation as 'John 117' is examined as a potential reference to Christ-like divinity or justice. By tracing these parallels, the text reveals that Halo’s universe is not merely science fiction, but a sophisticated modern mythology built upon ancient themes of sacrifice, false prophecy, and the preservation of life.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Assassin's Creed Shadows Slammed for Historical Errors and Unauthorized Material

ARTICLE | ~5 MIN

https://japan-forward.com/assassins-creed-shadows-slammed-for-historical-errors-and-unauthorized-material/

The article explores the backlash surrounding Ubisoft's video game Assassin's Creed Shadows, focusing on its cultural insensitivity and historical inaccuracies. It details how the game has sparked outrage by unauthorized use of sacred Japanese sites, such as allowing players to vandalize a real 1,400-year-old Shinto shrine, alongside concerns that fictionalized elements regarding the historical figure Yasuke will be mistaken for actual history. Ultimately, the text highlights the broader tension between creative artistic license and the imperative to respect cultural heritage, as both local communities and global fans demand greater accountability from the developers.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Assassin's Creed Was Always Anti-Religion?

YOUTUBE | ~35 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_nhdNwxXrvU

This video explores the controversy surrounding Assassin’s Creed Shadows and argues that the franchise has a long-standing history of being critically skeptical toward religion. The speakers contend that recent backlash regarding the desecration of a Japanese shrine in the game ignores the fact that previous entries frequently

portrayed major religious figures and deities as mere humans wielding technological artifacts. By examining past installments-such as the depiction of a corrupt Pope and the reinterpretation of religious miracles as precursor technology-the video suggests that the series has consistently treated spiritual traditions as subjective fiction. Ultimately, the authors lament that these cultural sensitivities and 'red herring' controversies are distracting from valid criticisms concerning Ubisoft’s business practices and historical inaccuracies.